

I recently sold my vacuum cleaner. It was just gathering dust.

I love the F5 key. It's just so refreshing.

ers equate to laughing. Rats are easily trained with using both positive and negative reinforcement – they will do, or avoid doing things based on whether they are rewarded or punished for doing certain things. The researchers at Washington State University who conducted the experiment are convinced that it is a positive response (as in, the rats like being tickled) because they use tickling as a reward. The rats were willing to solve mazes and press levers, etc., (which they normally do in exchange for treats), once they knew they would be rewarded with a good tickling after completing the task.

Of course it is totally possible that this trait evolved completely independently from the way it evolved in the great apes and us. In fact there have been several examples of independent evolution of traits or features in animals. The researchers behind this study are of the opinion that all mammals exhibit joy, and thus joy is a primitive emotion that spans many more species than we know of. However, this is contested by other scientists, and is not supported by data, so we have to chalk it up to being merely a gut feeling, and not good science.

HUMOUR

Responding to tickling is not the same as humour though, and this is where things get far more complex. Since we are incapable of truly understanding humour for other species, we're going to stick to *Homo Sapiens Sapiens* in order to try and understand it, and hopefully trace back to the origins.

Given that humour seems to be inbuilt into us, and from a very young age (even babies laugh at silly things), and isn't even dependent on language or really anything we learn later in life, researchers believe that it has to be genetic. Something in our DNA must code us to find things humorous, and no human culture we know of has not displayed the ability to partake in humour. Ancient Greeks give us a verifiable historical record of there being jesters and jokes as far back as the records go. In fact, it must go back

to far, far before them as well, because the Australian Aborigines also showed the ability to understand and partake in humour during their first contact. Since Australian Aborigines are considered to be the most isolated group of humans on the planet*, it's obvious that humour predates them as well.

If we want to establish a timeline of humour, we have certainly already pushed it back 35,000 years, at the minimum, which is prehistoric, and thus, is impossible to nail down for sure. In terms of timelines, we have to be willing to accept "older than 35k years" as an answer. If we go by the last common ancestor of the great apes and us, we'd have to go all the way back to the last ancestor we had in common with the orangutans, which is about 14 million years ago!

If we can't nail down when it started, can we at least nail down why it started, or perhaps even how it started? For humour to have achieved the universal appeal it enjoys now, it would have had to be beneficial to the species, the group, family or individual, because evolution demands that there be an advantage to something at those levels, or else it just will not "catch on" like it has.

One theory suggests that humour is essentially the discovery of something that doesn't fit. There are many incongruity theories of humour, but what's common amongst them all is the idea that humans benefit from spotting incongruities around them. Many jokes contain punchlines that are often unexpected and catch us by surprise. Somewhat like misdirection done by a magician, a joke teller relies on you not jumping ahead and ruining the surprise, yet also following the path faithfully... eventually when the punchline comes, you immediately spot the incongruity, and laugh at the joke. That laughter is not something you control, and the understanding of the joke is not something that needs to be scrutinised first, the laughter just flows naturally.

Another theory suggests that humour is nothing more than repressed

aggression and sexual feelings, and it's why so many jokes revolve around aggression or sex, in some form or the other. This obviously isn't universal, because we often laugh at silly things that don't involve either sex or violence in any shape or form, but that isn't the majority of jokes out there these days.

A third theory is that humour probably evolved in order to elevate one's social standing. Given that everyone wants a mate, but not everyone has the bodies or looks of Greek gods, it has been suggested that humour might have been used by the brainy to put down the brawny in ancient history. A good joke teller who could make people lose inhibitions and laugh openly would perhaps have had his social status raised, while he might have made the jokes at the expense of others. Because jokes aren't a physical threat, it would stand to reason that physical retaliation against a joker would be frowned upon by the group, and thus can perhaps explain its persistence over the years.

We wish there was a definitive answer to how humour originated, but the fact is, we're still trying to find out. The only reason this article wasn't published as a Science > Ignorance piece is because the Ed already had a particular topic for it that we know even less about!

Normally we ask you to write in with feedback, but instead we want you to write in and tell us the funniest joke you have ever read / heard. The joke the team finds the funniest will win... err... whatever stuff we have lying around that we don't want anymore. **4**

Sources of information/suggested reading

- The origin of humor – N. E. Howe
- The First Joke: Exploring the Evolutionary Origins of Humor – J Polimeni and J Reiss
- Creativity and Humor: A volume in Explorations in Creativity Research – Various Authors – ISBN: 9780128138021
- Benign Violations : Making Immoral Behavior Funny – A. P. McGraw and C. Warren
- Telling the world's least funny jokes: On the quantification of humor as entropy – C. Westbury, C. Shaoul, G. Moroschan, M. Ramscar

* Australian aborigines are considered to have been cut off from the rest of the world for at least 35,000 years before the Europeans landed in Australia. In fact, all of Australia before the Europeans is essentially a closed evolutionary bubble that was completely separated from the rest of the world.